

OxygenOS 15.0, which is based on Android 15. The OS has surprisingly low bloatware; there were only a few preinstalled apps, and most of them were OnePlus' own apps. The interface is intuitive, snappy, and packed with useful features that enhance productivity and customisation.

OnePlus offers four years of major software updates and six years of security patches. While this isn't as extensive as Samsung's update policy, it's still competitive in the flagship segment.

AI

OnePlus has incorporated several AI-powered features into the OnePlus 13, and they genuinely enhance the user experience. The standout feature is Intelligent Search, which allows users to ask natural-language questions to quickly find specific information stored on the device. Whether it's details about a flight or a saved document, the AI is fast, accurate, and incredibly useful for productivity.

Other features include AI-driven photo editing and text generation tools, which simplify everyday tasks like tweaking images or creating captions. These features feel purposeful and avoid the 'gimmick' label that often plagues AI implementations in smartphones. In our Digit AI-Q tests, the OnePlus 13 scored an impressive 85/100, highlighting its well-rounded capabilities in this area.

CAMERAS

While the hardware is impressive on paper, real-world performance is more of a mixed bag. Under well-lit conditions, the OnePlus 13's primary camera captures images with excellent detail, vibrant colours, and a wide dynamic range. Photos are sharp and punchy, but they lean slightly toward overexposure in very bright environments. This is particularly noticeable in scenes with high contrast, where highlights can sometimes appear blown out.

Portrait mode is one of the camera's strengths, with accurate edge detection and natural-looking background blur. Skin tones, while not flawless, are the most realistic we've seen from a OnePlus flagship to date. The 50 MP ultra-wide camera on the OnePlus 13 offers sharp and distortion-free

images, maintaining consistent colour reproduction with the primary sensor. It also doubles as a macro lens, allowing for highly detailed close-up shots. However, the ultra-wide lens does struggle with lens flare in backlit scenarios, so some caution is needed when shooting in challenging lighting conditions.

The 50 MP periscope telephoto lens provides a clean, optical 3x zoom and maintains good detail up to 6x. Images captured within this range are sharp and vibrant, making the telephoto lens ideal for portraiture and distant subjects. Beyond 6x, however, the quality starts to degrade, with noticeable softness and a loss of detail. While the OnePlus 13 isn't trying to compete with the 10x or 100x zoom capabilities of some rivals, its telephoto performance is solid for everyday use.

When the lights go down, the OnePlus 13's camera system shows both its strengths and its limitations. In moderately lit environments, the primary sensor captures impressive shots with good detail, accurate colours, and minimal noise. However, in extreme low-light conditions, the phone starts to struggle. Noise becomes more apparent, and details can appear soft, particularly in shadows. The dedicated Night Mode helps mitigate these issues to some extent but doesn't match the low-light prowess of competitors like the Vivo X200 Pro or Google Pixel 9 Pro.

The OnePlus 13 offers a robust set of video recording options, including 8K at 30 fps and 4K at 60 fps. You also get Dolby Vision support for enhanced dynamic range and vibrant colours. Video stabilisation is excellent, making handheld shooting smooth and steady. However, the absence of 4K at 120 fps is a noticeable gap for video enthusiasts who enjoy capturing high-quality slow-motion footage.

For photography enthusiasts, the Master Mode is a standout feature. It provides full manual control over settings like ISO, shutter speed, focus, and white balance, allowing users to fine-tune their shots. The ability to shoot in RAW format is also quite nifty. The 32 MP front-facing camera performs well in good lighting

conditions, producing sharp and detailed selfies with natural skin tones. However, its fixed focus can be limiting, and results in less-than-perfect images in group selfies or when shooting from unconventional angles. Low-light selfies also show some noise and a slight loss of detail.

BATTERY LIFE

Battery life is one of the standout features of the OnePlus 13. Whether you're a light or heavy user, you can expect between 9 to 11 hours of screen-on time, making battery anxiety a thing of the past. When it's time to recharge, the 100 W wired fast charging gets the battery from 0 to 100% in just 36 minutes. The phone also supports 50 W wireless charging, but you'll need OnePlus' proprietary AIRVOOC charger for optimal results.

VERDICT

The OnePlus 13 is a return to form for the brand, offering a compelling mix of performance, design, and battery life. Its sleek and refined design, combined with top-tier hardware and thoughtful AI features, make it an excellent choice for most users. While the cameras and display don't break new ground, they are more than sufficient for everyday use. However, the OnePlus 13 faces stiff competition from devices like the Vivo X200 Pro and OPPO Find X8 Pro, which offer superior cameras. So, if photography is your main priority, the OnePlus 13 isn't the best option out there for you. However, for users who prioritise performance, battery life, and a premium design, the OnePlus 13 is a strong contender and a worthy flagship in 2025.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Snapdragon 8 Elite | OS: Android 15, OxygenOS 15 | RAM: 12/16/24 GB | Storage: 256 GB/512 GB/1 TB | IP Rating: IP68/IP69 | Display: 6.82 LTPO 4.1 AMOLED, 1440 x 3168 pixels | Refresh Rate: 120 Hz | Display protection: Ceramic Guard | Cameras: 50 MP + 50 MP + 50 MP | Selfie Camera: 32 MP | Battery: 6,000 mAh | Charging: 100 W wired, 50 W wireless, 10 W reverse wireless

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